the Mujahideen government in 1989, and it was time for India to show the Mujahideen that they were not only dependent on Pakistan, and that 'their brother nation India could be there for them too'.[56] Given his political evolution into a radical Hindu nationalist today, Swamy seems an unlikely conciliator vis-à-vis the Mujahideen (but such are the quirks of Indian politics).

Swamy's use of the term 'brother nation', however, had a strong cultural context, that being the Kabuliwallah connection. Despite New Delhi's political choices, India was adored among Afghans, including the Mujahideen. In 1991, when Bollywood superstar Amitabh Bachchan visited Afghanistan to shoot for his film *Khuda Gawah* (God is Witness), he was welcomed with open arms by Afghans from all walks of life, despite the precarious security situation.[57] The goodwill quotient among Afghans not only made it easy for the conciliators to pursue a friendly relationship with the Mujahideen, but also made it senseless to not have such relations. When some MPs objected to Swamy's conciliatory advocacy, citing concerns of what Moscow would make of it, Swamy wittily replied:

> Don't worry. Moscow knows that you [India] are a loyal servant of theirs. Pakistan is fully supporting the Mujahideens and our continued hostility towards the Mujahideens would mean that ultimately Pakistan and Afghanistan would get together at the cost of our national interest. Therefore, I suggest that we immediately take diplomatic initiatives to see that India's image in Afghanistan—and particularly amongst the freedom-loving people of Afghanistan—is restored, that by taking suitable initiatives we are able to once again play a role.[58]

India's conciliatory u-turn was not just driven by its desire to survive, but also, if not equally, by its economic interests and ambitions. The Soviet Union's disintegration had created five new resource-rich states in Central Asia: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan. India was in a race to access these resources. New Delhi was viewing Afghanistan not just in a South Asian context, but also in a Central Asian context. According to a senior Indian diplomat, posted in Iran in the late 1980s, 'Central Asian states were becoming independent and had a lot of natural resources that we [India] wanted to access. Our concern was that if we don't do this, the Chinese or other countries would take over. So we knew that we needed to be active'.[59] Indeed, India signed a list of MoUs with the Central Asian states in 1993 and tried to cultivate strong and friendly relations with all. The BJP, for instance, kept pushing Rao to detail